THE DEFINITIVE GUIDE TO

The Trainer's Programming Blueprint

How **Elite S&C Coaches** Build Programs That Keep Clients Engaged, Progressing, and Paying — For Years.

6	12	1,344
PHASES	WEEK TEMPLATE	EXERCISES

INTRODUCTION

Why Most Trainers Lose Clients After 3 Months

The 90-Day Dropout Problem

Research consistently shows that **over 60% of personal training clients quit within their first three months**. The reason is almost never the trainer's personality or gym quality. It's the program. Clients plateau, get confused, or feel like they're just doing random workouts with no clear direction — and they leave.

THE CORE PROBLEM

A random collection of exercises is **not** a program. A program is a purposeful, periodised sequence of training stimuli designed to produce a specific physiological adaptation over time. Without periodisation, clients stop progressing. Without progression, they stop paying.

Program vs. Random Exercises

A real program manipulates load, volume, intensity, and rest in a calculated sequence. Each session builds on the last.

The Progression Equation

Systematic overload + appropriate recovery = sustainable adaptation. Miss either side and results stall permanently.

What This Blueprint Will Teach You

- The 6-phase periodisation framework used by elite strength & conditioning coaches worldwide
- How to monitor training load using the Acute:Chronic Workload Ratio to prevent overtraining and injury
- The RPE vs percentage-based loading debate — and when to use each method with your clients
- A complete 12-week hypertrophy block template you can use immediately with any client
- A systematic exercise selection framework using Push/Pull/Legs from 1,344+ exercises
- The client assessment checklist that feeds directly into your EvoFit Trainer programming workflow

CHAPTER 1

The 6-Phase Periodisation Framework

EvoFit

Periodisation is the systematic planning of athletic training. It involves progressive cycling of various aspects of a training program during a specific period. Here are the six phases every complete annual plan should include:

1

Anatomical Adaptation 2–4 WEEKS

Prepares tendons, ligaments, and stabiliser muscles for heavier loading ahead. High reps (15–20), light loads, full body movements. This phase is often skipped by impatient trainers — and later regretted. Injury prevention starts here.

2

Hypertrophy 6–12 WEEKS

The foundation of physique development. Moderate loads (67–85% 1RM), moderate-to-high volume (3–5 sets of 8–15 reps). Metabolic stress and mechanical tension drive muscle growth. This is where most client transformations are built.

3

Strength 4–8 WEEKS

Builds maximal force production by recruiting more motor units. Heavy loads (85–95% 1RM), lower reps (3–6), longer rest periods (3–5 min). Neural adaptations take priority over muscle growth in this phase.

4

Power 2–4 WEEKS

Converts strength gains into explosive force. Submaximal loads (30–70% 1RM) moved as fast as possible. Olympic lifts, plyometrics, medicine ball throws. Primarily for athletes, but adds variety and athleticism for general clients.

5

Peaking 1–3 WEEKS

Maximises performance for a specific event, competition, or test. Volume drops significantly (40–60%), intensity stays high. Allows full recovery while maintaining strength. Used before competitions, photoshoots, or milestone assessments.

6

Active Recovery 1–2 WEEKS

Structured rest that allows physiological and psychological restoration. Light movement, mobility, low-intensity cardio. Supercompensation (the rebound effect) occurs here — skip it and you leave gains on the table.

ACWR Training Load Monitoring

The **Acute:Chronic Workload Ratio (ACWR)** is the gold-standard method for monitoring whether your client is training at a productive level or drifting into overtraining territory. Originally developed in elite sport science, it's now accessible to every trainer through modern coaching software.

THE ACWR FORMULA

Acute (7-day training load) ÷ **Chronic** (28-day training load) = **ACWR Score** (Target: 0.8 – 1.3)

Training load is calculated as **session RPE × duration (minutes)**. For example, a client who rates a 60-minute session at RPE 7 generates a load score of 420 arbitrary units (AU). Track this daily, and the rolling average tells you exactly where your client sits on the readiness spectrum.

< 0.8
UNDERTRAINING
Load too low. Client is deconditioned, losing fitness. Increase training stimulus.

0.8 – 1.3
SWEET SPOT
Optimal training zone. Client is adapting safely. Maintain or incrementally progress.

> 1.5
DANGER ZONE
Injury risk 2–4× higher. Load increased too fast. Immediate volume reduction required.

⚠️ **The Spike Warning:** A single hard week after low training volume is one of the highest injury predictors. Never increase weekly load by more than 10% and always ensure your 28-day chronic load base supports the acute demand. "Doing too much too soon" is responsible for the majority of non-contact training injuries.

How EvoFit Trainer Automates ACWR

EvoFit Trainer automatically calculates your clients' ACWR from logged workout data. The dashboard flags clients approaching the danger zone in real time, so you can adjust programming before injury occurs — not after. No spreadsheets. No manual calculations.

RPE vs Percentage-Based Loading

The debate between autoregulated RPE loading and fixed percentage-based programming is one of the most practical decisions you'll make for each client. The truth? Neither is universally superior — context determines which wins.

RPE	EFFORT DESCRIPTION	REPS IN RESERVE	BEST USE CASE
6	Comfortable, could talk easily	**4+ reps left**	Warm-up sets, beginners
7	Moderate effort, still comfortable	**3 reps left**	Foundation phase
8	Challenging but controlled	**2 reps left**	Hypertrophy & strength
9	Very hard, form starting to strain	**1 rep left**	Intensification, peaking
10	Maximal effort, true 1RM	**0 reps left**	Testing only, not training

Use RPE When:

- Client is intermediate or advanced (self-aware)
- Daily readiness fluctuates (poor sleep, stress)
- No recent 1RM test data is available
- Autoregulation fits client psychology
- Injury rehab requires daily load modulation

Use Percentages When:

- Client is a beginner (no reliable RPE gauge)
- Peaking for a tested competition
- You have recent, reliable 1RM data
- Client prefers structure over intuition
- Accessory lifts with fixed progression targets

The Blended Approach (Recommended for Most Clients)

Use **RPE for main compound lifts** (squat, deadlift, bench, press, row) where daily readiness significantly impacts safe loading. Use **percentage-based loading for accessories** where consistency matters more than autoregulation. EvoFit Trainer's progression engine supports both simultaneously — assign RPE targets to primary movements and fixed percentages to secondary work, all within the same program block.

The 12-Week Hypertrophy Block Template

A 12-week hypertrophy block is the most requested program structure in general fitness. Here is a battle-tested template structured into three 4-week mesocycles with built-in deload weeks for recovery and supercompensation.

I Foundation — Building the Base

Weeks 1–4

WEEK	SETS × REPS	RPE TARGET	REST PERIOD	TEMPO	NOTES
Wk 1	3 × 12	RPE 6	90 sec	3-0-1-0	Establish technique, light load
Wk 2	3 × 10	RPE 6–7	90 sec	3-0-1-0	Small load increase
Wk 3	3 × 10	RPE 7	90 sec	3-1-1-0	Add eccentric pause
Wk 4	*2 × 10*	*RPE 5–6*	*60 sec*	*2-0-1-0*	*Deload — 60% volume*

II Volume Accumulation

Weeks 5–8

WEEK	SETS × REPS	RPE TARGET	REST PERIOD	TEMPO	NOTES
Wk 5	4 × 10	RPE 7	90–120 sec	3-0-1-0	Volume jump — expect soreness
Wk 6	4 × 8	RPE 7–8	2 min	3-1-1-0	Load increases, reps reduce
Wk 7	4 × 8	RPE 8	2 min	3-1-1-1	Peak volume week
Wk 8	*3 × 8*	*RPE 5–6*	*90 sec*	*2-0-1-0*	*Deload — 60% volume*

III Intensification

Weeks 9–12

WEEK	SETS × REPS	RPE TARGET	REST PERIOD	TEMPO	NOTES
Wk 9	5 × 6	RPE 7–8	2–3 min	2-1-1-0	Transition to strength emphasis
Wk 10	5 × 5	RPE 8	3 min	2-1-1-1	Heavier loads, fewer reps
Wk 11	5 × 5	RPE 8–9	3–4 min	2-1-1-1	Near-maximal intensification
Wk 12	3 × 3	RPE 9	4 min	2-0-1-0	Peaking week — test new maxes

Tempo notation: Eccentric–Pause at bottom–Concentric–Pause at top (seconds). E.g. 3-1-1-0 = 3s lower, 1s pause, 1s lift, no pause at top.

Exercise Selection Framework

With 1,344 exercises in the EvoFit Trainer library, smart selection is critical. The Push/Pull/Legs framework provides a biomechanically balanced structure that prevents overuse injuries and ensures every major muscle group receives adequate volume throughout the week.

Push Day

Chest, Shoulders, Triceps

- Barbell Bench Press
- Incline DB Press
- Overhead Press
- Lateral Raises
- Tricep Pushdown
- Cable Flye

Pull Day

Back, Biceps, Rear Delts

- Deadlift / RDL
- Pull-ups / Lat Pulldown
- Barbell Row
- Face Pulls
- Barbell Curl
- Hammer Curl

Leg Day

Quads, Hamstrings, Glutes, Calves

- Back Squat / Front Squat
- Romanian Deadlift
- Leg Press
- Bulgarian Split Squat
- Leg Curl
- Standing Calf Raise

80%

The 80/20 Rule of Exercise Selection

80% of your clients' results come from 20% of their exercises. Compound, multi-joint movements — squats, deadlifts, pressing, pulling — drive the overwhelming majority of strength, hypertrophy, and body composition changes. Fill primary slots with these first, then use accessories to address weak points, add volume, or improve aesthetics.

Home Gym Programming — Minimal Kit

- → Dumbbells: Romanian DL, DB Press, DB Row, Lunges
- → Resistance bands: Face pulls, lateral raises, rows
- → Bodyweight: Push-ups, pull-ups, dips, single-leg work
- → Focus on unilateral movements to address imbalances

Commercial Gym Programming — Full Kit

- → Barbell compounds as primary movements every session
- → Cable machines for constant tension on accessories
- → Machines for isolated hypertrophy (leg extension, etc.)
- → Filter by equipment in EvoFit Trainer's exercise library

Client Assessment Checklist

A thorough initial assessment is the difference between a generic program and a life-changing one. Use this checklist before building any client's first program. This data feeds directly into EvoFit Trainer's client profile, enabling personalised programming from day one.

1 PAR-Q Health Screening

- [ ] Has a doctor ever told them they have a heart condition?
- [ ] Do they feel chest pain during physical activity?
- [ ] Have they experienced dizziness or loss of consciousness?
- [ ] Any bone or joint problems aggravated by exercise?
- [ ] Currently on any medication affecting exercise safety?
- [ ] Any other condition requiring medical supervision?

2 Movement Screen Basics

- [ ] Overhead squat assessment (hip mobility, ankle dorsiflexion)
- [ ] Single-leg balance test (stability, proprioception)
- [ ] Hip hinge pattern (deadlift mechanics, hamstring flexibility)
- [ ] Thoracic spine rotation (overhead press capability)
- [ ] Push pattern (scapular control, anterior shoulder)
- [ ] Pull pattern (lat engagement, elbow path)

3 Goal-Setting Framework

- [ ] Primary goal: strength / hypertrophy / performance / general fitness
- [ ] Timeline: when do they need to achieve the goal?
- [ ] Training history: years, frequency, injuries
- [ ] Available training days per week (3, 4, 5, or 6?)
- [ ] Session duration available (45, 60, 90 min?)
- [ ] Equipment access: home gym, commercial, outdoor?

4 Baseline Performance Metrics

- [ ] Max push-ups (unbroken, bodyweight baseline)
- [ ] 1RM or estimated 1RM on primary compound lifts
- [ ] Bodyweight measurements (if relevant to goals)
- [ ] Resting heart rate and HRV if available
- [ ] Prior injury history documented and flagged
- [ ] Lifestyle factors: sleep quality, stress levels

How This Data Flows Into EvoFit Trainer

Assessment — PAR-Q + Screen
→ **Client Profile** — Goals + History
→ **Program Design** — Periodised plan
→ **Track Progress** — ACWR + RPE data
→ **Auto-Adjust** — Progression engine

READY TO PUT THIS INTO ACTION?

Stop Building Programs in Spreadsheets. Own Your Platform.

EvoFit Trainer gives you everything in this blueprint — periodisation tools, ACWR monitoring, RPE progression, 1,344 exercises, and client management — in one platform you pay for once and own forever.

STARTER

$49

One-time payment

- ✓ Up to 10 active clients
- ✓ Full exercise library (1,344)
- ✓ Program builder + templates
- ✓ Workout tracking + RPE logging
- ✓ Progress analytics dashboard

MOST POPULAR

PROFESSIONAL

$149

One-time payment

- ✓ Unlimited clients
- ✓ Everything in Starter
- ✓ ACWR load monitoring
- ✓ Auto-progression engine (RPE)
- ✓ Calendar export + scheduling
- ✓ Client messaging

ENTERPRISE

$299

One-time payment

- ✓ Multi-trainer team access
- ✓ Everything in Professional
- ✓ White-label branding
- ✓ Admin dashboard + reporting
- ✓ Priority support

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